National Interagency Coordination Center

Wildland Fire Summary and Statistics Annual Report 2025

Elk Springs Fire, Colorado

National Interagency Coordination Center

PREDICTIVE SERVICES

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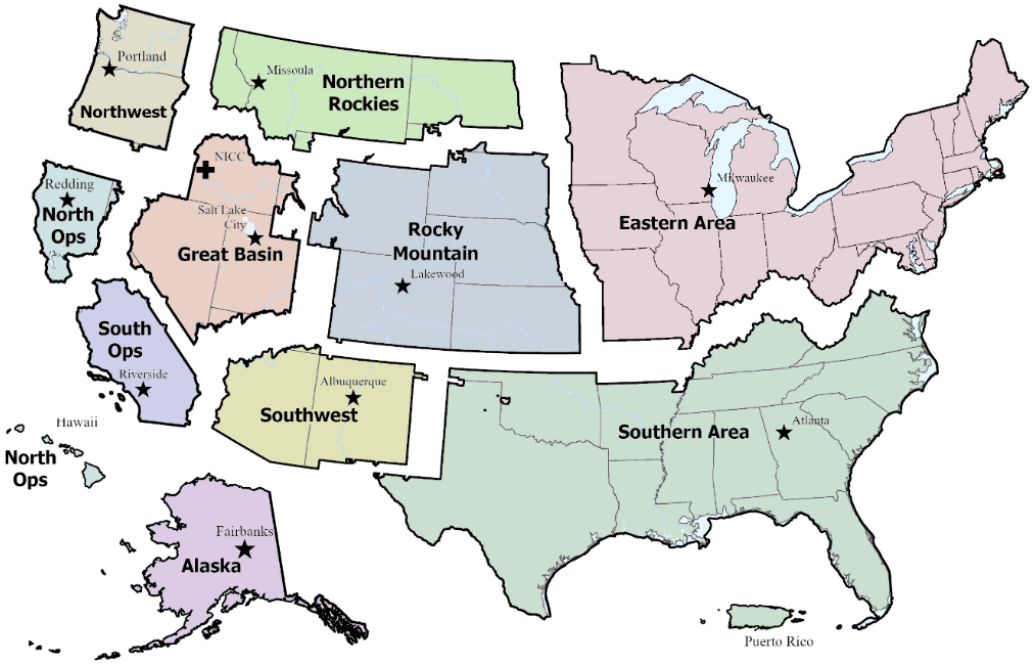
Preface

Statistics used in this report were gathered from the Situation Report and Incident Status Summary (ICS-209) programs[1]. Previous National Interagency Coordination Center (NICC) annual reports and other sources were also used in this document. The statistics presented here are intended to provide a national perspective of annual fire activity, but they may not reflect official figures for a specific agency. The statistics are delineated by agency and Geographic Area. This document and prior year annual reports are available electronically on the NICC Intelligence web page.

Resource mobilization statistics used in this report were gathered from the Interagency Resource Ordering Capability system (IROC), which tracks aircraft, crews, equipment, overhead, and supplies mobilized nationally. Statistics presented in this report are resources requested by any of the ten Geographic Area Coordination Centers (GACCs) and processed through NICC, apart from Incident Management Teams and Temporary Flight Restrictions[2]. Requests by FEMA are placed to NICC through Emergency Support Function (ESF) #4 (Firefighting). The resource ordering process and procedures may be found in the National Interagency Standards for Resource Mobilization (NISRM). The NISRM can be found on the NICC Reference Documents web page.

Geographic Area Coordination Centers



[1] Situation Report and ICS-209 data are considered situational and provisional, as they are reported while wildfire activity and incidents are occurring, plus they do not account for all wildland fires and their final outcomes. Some wildfires, including many that are suppressed solely by private citizens or local fire departments (not by wildland fire management agencies), are never reported to any Dispatch Center that submits Situation Report data. Additionally, ICS-209 reports are not required for the small, short duration wildfires that comprise the vast majority of overall fire occurrence annually. For official data and summary statistics, one must contact each of the individual agencies affected and refer to their final fire reports and other authoritative sources of agency-specific information.

[2] This report only tallies resource requests processed through NICC, with the exceptions of Incident Management Team mobilizations and Temporary Flight Restrictions that are captured nationally. It excludes the substantial number of IROC orders that were placed and filled within the same GACC. It also excludes any resource usage not tracked in IROC, such as local dispatch of initial attack resources.

2025 Fire Environment Summary

January – March
A pattern typical of La Niña developed across the West January through March, with near to below normal temperatures in the northwestern US along with generally above normal precipitation, except along the Canadian border, where precipitation was slightly below normal. Mild and drier than normal conditions were observed in the southwestern US into the southern Plains, with portions of West Texas receiving less than 5% of normal precipitation for the three-month period. This precipitation and temperature pattern resulted in peak snowpack at the end of March being near to above normal for most of the northern two-thirds of the US, except along the Canadian border, which was slightly below normal. Of these far northern basins, snowpack in the higher elevations was near normal but well below normal in the lower elevations below 4,000 feet. In the Southwest, the mild and dry winter resulted in a snowpack that was well below normal.

The three-month average temperature for much of the eastern US was near normal, with mainly below normal temperatures on the Plains. However, a significant amount of cold air affected the eastern US the latter half of January, with the strongest winter storm in decades bringing heavy snow to the northern Gulf Coast, including 8 inches in New Orleans, Louisiana. Despite the near normal temperatures for most of this area, precipitation was mostly below normal, especially on the Plains. Only small areas of above normal precipitation were observed in the Upper Great Lakes, Kentucky, and Deep South Texas. Snowpack in the eastern U.S. was also below normal, especially in Minnesota, with many areas devoid of snow for much of the winter. Despite the lack of snow overall, a strong ice storm hit northern Michigan at the end of March, with significant damage to vegetation.

Significant fire activity was at generally low levels for the first quarter of the year but pulsed periodically with notable increases in activity in January and much of March, and the National Preparedness Level (PL) was increased to two (on a scale of 1-5) during those periods. The active period in January began with a very strong Santa Ana wind event in Southern California January 7-9 when wind gusts to 100 mph were observed along with relative humidity of 5-15%. Two more significant Santa Ana events occurred January 12-15 and January 20-24, with over a dozen fires emerging during the three events. The two biggest fires, the Palisades and Eaton Fires, burned almost 38,000 acres combined and resulted in over 30 civilian fatalities and 16,000 structures destroyed. The season's first Fuels and Fire Behavior Advisory was issued for Southern California's coast and adjacent interior mountains to highlight the potential for extreme fire behavior due to record low fuel moisture values and the recurring wind events.

The other significant period of fire activity occurred in late February into mid-March in the Southern Area, both in the southern Plains and southern Appalachians. A very dry period at the end of February in the southern Appalachians resulted in several days of minimum relative humidity falling to 10-20% and poor overnight recovery. This period rapidly dried fuels, which dried further in the southern Appalachians due to an anomalously dry and windy month. A Fuels and Fire Behavior Advisory was issued for portions of the Carolinas, north Georgia, and eastern Tennessee, noting these concerns. Several large fires emerged requiring complex incident management teams, including the Covington Drive Fire near Myrtle Beach, South Carolina. Meanwhile, farther west in the southern Plains, March began windy and very dry, culminating in an extreme wind event March 14 from North Texas through Oklahoma into southeast Kansas and southwest Missouri. This wind event brought sustained winds 40-60

mph with gusts to 80 mph amid relative humidity of 5-20%. A fire outbreak occurred on the southern Plains with this event, focused on Oklahoma, where more than a dozen fires burned over 50,000 acres and hundreds of structures were destroyed. Periodic wind events continued on the southern Plains the remainder of the month, with several additional large fires. The combination of dry, freeze-cured grasses and the recurrent wind events were highlighted with a Fuels and Fire Behavior Advisory issued jointly through Southern, Southwest, and Rocky Mountain Geographic Area Coordination Centers and encompassing over 60 million acres, from eastern Colorado and New Mexico into the Texas Panhandle, much of Oklahoma, and southern Kansas.

April – June

A warm and dry period was observed across much of the West April through June as temperatures averaged 1-4 degrees above normal. Precipitation was below normal for the northern two-thirds of the West, focused west of the Divide, with much of California the northern Great Basin, and Northwest receiving less than 50% of normal precipitation. However, most of the Southwest received above normal precipitation, focused on two storms in early May and early June. Portions of the Lower Colorado River Valley and western Arizona received more than 400% of normal precipitation, with northeast Arizona and eastern New Mexico also well above normal. The warm and dry period resulted in a rapid melting of the snowpack in the West, with many areas below 6,000 feet melting off two to three weeks early. Overall drought improved slightly in the Southwest, but much of the northern and central Rockies into the Northwest observed a significant expansion of drought.

After the very dry winter in the Plains, it became much wetter April through June, especially on the southern Plains, which fostered abundant grass growth and above-normal fine fuel loading. Wetter than normal conditions were also observed across much of the Lower Mississippi Valley, Appalachians, and East Coast, but Florida was slightly drier than average. However, much of the Midwest was drier than normal through May. Temperatures were near to above normal for much of the Plains to East Coast, but an exceptional warm period occurred in the Midwest in mid-May, with Minnesota setting the record earliest 100°F temperature May 11. June then followed with above normal precipitation for most of the Midwest. In late June, a strong derecho moved through eastern North Dakota into northern Minnesota. Wind gusts up to 106 mph were recorded, with significant blow down of trees in northern Minnesota centered around Bemidji.

Contrary to expectations for above normal fire potential to continue in parts of the Southeast and southern Plains, fire activity was benign for most of April across the country, with the PL decreasing to one in early April. Despite the relatively quiet month, a few large fires emerged at times, including the Jones Road Fire in New Jersey April 22 that burned over 15,000 acres. Fire activity then began to gradually increase across the West and the rest of the Eastern Area in May, with the most abundant activity in the Midwest in mid-May because of the significant heat wave. This heat wave also occurred with periods of breezy southerly winds, resulting in several significant fires May 12-14 in Minnesota. The largest of these fires, the Camp House Fire near Brimson, Minnesota resulted in 187 destroyed structures. The national PL was increased to two May 14 in response to these fires and a very slow rise in activity in the West.

Fire activity in the Eastern Area declined late in May and continued to abate into June as green-up occurred. The Southern Area observed a gradual decline in activity all three months, although periodic large fires occurred in Florida, especially South Florida, which is a normal

occurrence until the wet season begins in earnest in late June and July. In the West, fire activity continued a gradual increase in June despite expectations for an earlier and more active than normal start to the core fire season, as was highlighted with Fuels and Fire Behavior Advisories citing the poor winter snowpack and ongoing drought for parts of Arizona, New Mexico, and Utah. The Southwest remained remarkably quiet through the middle of June due to the anomalous precipitation received early in the month. Afterward, activity increased in the Southwest as scattered thunderstorms June 8-10 resulted in several new large fires in subsequent days as temperatures rose to well above normal amid very low relative humidity in the single digits. This pattern also affected the Great Basin with several new large fires, most notably in the southern Great Basin as two complex incident management teams managed fires in southern Utah. As drought conditions gradually returned and worsened in parts of the Northwest, fuels became drier than normal and receptive to ignition. On June 11, the Rowena Fire ignited on the south side of the Columbia River west of The Dalles and escalated rapidly due to high winds, burning over 160 structures within hours.

While the West continued a gradual increase in activity the latter half of June, a more significant increase in activity occurred in Alaska. A prolonged heat wave across the Interior resulted in several days of temperatures above 80°F amid low relative humidity. Isolated to scattered thunderstorms also occurred the latter half of the event and resulted in numerous significant fires across the Interior, including several around Fairbanks that required a complex incident management team. Five fires that ignited around solstice continued to burn actively into the early summer and eventually consumed more than 50,000 acres each, with the largest being the Tanana Zone's Klikhtentotzna Fire that ultimately burned nearly 118,000 acres. Due to the rapid escalation in Alaska and the gradual increase in activity in the West, the national PL was increased to three June 21.

July – September

Fire activity increased across the West rapidly the first two weeks of July, while Alaska saw a gradual decrease in activity as cooler, wetter weather moved into the state. Several days of lightning in northern California and the Northwest at the beginning of the month ignited hundreds of new fires due to the dry fuels, with several requiring complex incident management teams. However, the lightning was accompanied by locally heavy precipitation, which resulted in most fires being easily managed and controlled after ignition. The Madre Fire, which would burn over 80,000 acres, ignited July 2 on the Los Padres National Forest in Southern California, raising concerns that July might be busier than normal in the Pacific Southwest, but few other large fires arose there over the month.

The very dry conditions from the winter that were a concern for the Southwest, southern Great Basin, and West Slope bore fruit as several new significant fires emerged in the first two weeks in July. The Dragon Bravo Fire in Grand Canyon National Park and the Monroe Canyon Fire in central Utah were very active during this period. A significant dry lightning event also affected the West Slope July 10, resulting in Colorado's South Rim and Turner Gulch Fires, and other large fires in the interior West, and three complex incident management teams mobilized. The national PL was increased to four July 12 due to the increase in activity in several geographic areas. These fires were temporarily less active the third week of the month as a brief pulse of monsoon moisture affected the Greater Four Corners. While a few of the significant fires were contained during this period, resulting in the national PL decreasing to

three July 28, several became very active again toward the end of the month. Notably, the Dragon Bravo and Monroe Canyon Fires became extremely active July 23-31 with large plumes daily. Both would continue to burn actively through the summer, with the Dragon Bravo becoming the nation's largest fire for 2025 at 146,000 acres. By the end of July, with only limited benefit of that sporadic monsoon moisture, much of the interior West, from the Arizona Strip to southern Wyoming, was covered by an expanded Fuels and Fire Behavior Advisory issued jointly by Great Basin and Rocky Mountain Coordination Centers. During the first half of July, Advisories were also issued for parts of Nevada, based on abnormally dry fuels and above normal fine fuel loading in some areas, and these concerns would continue through August.

While the southern half of the West was active during July, the Northern Rockies, northern Great Basin, and portions of the Northwest were much less active. An unusually active polar jet stream in July resulted in periods of cooler temperatures, precipitation, and limited lightning for new ignitions and provided opportunities for effective suppression operations on the relatively few large fires that arose. The Eastern and Southern Areas were seasonally less active. However, a much drier pattern emerged in the Northeast in mid-July, with portions of northern New England receiving less than 50% of normal July rainfall. Much of the Midwest and the Plains recorded above normal precipitation in July, with central Texas exceptionally wet. Intense rainfall occurred with thunderstorms July 4 in the Texas Hill Country producing catastrophic flooding that resulted in at least 135 deaths, mainly due to the rapid rise of the Guadalupe River.

Fire activity in the West increased in the first three weeks of August, first in the Greater Four Corners, then into the northern Great Basin, Wyoming, and Montana mid-month as many of these areas started August dry with above normal temperatures. The Fuels and Fire Behavior Advisory was expanded even more, to include all of Utah and Colorado's West Slope, plus the Arizona Strip and southwest Wyoming, by mid-August. While no major dry lightning events were observed, several smaller events occurred. These smaller events affected northern Nevada August 2, western Colorado August 4-5, and Wyoming August 14-16, with several new significant fires, and the national PL was raised to four August 5. These fires burned actively for several days, but activity here and in the Southwest wound down quickly at the end of the month as the first strong and widespread monsoon surge occurred. Despite this surge, precipitation was below normal for the Greater Four Corners as August is typically a wet month. This surge also affected the Sierra into the northern Great Basin, which resulted in well above normal precipitation, as August is one of the two driest months of the year in these areas. Little monsoon moisture found its way into Southern California, however, and a Fuels and Fire Behavior Advisory was issued for the dry fuels in the central Mojave Desert and inland mountains.

On August 1, the Gifford Fire, which would grow to over 130,000 acres, ignited on the Los Padres National Forest in Southern California. Fire activity farther north and west across California, the Northwest, and Northern Rockies remained at moderate to low levels during the month. Notable increases in these areas occurred in mid-August, late August, and mid-August, respectively. However, the moderate increases in activity in these areas were not as much to offset the overall lower activity in the Rocky Mountain, Southwest, and Great Basin Areas, resulting in the national PL dropping to three August 30. In addition to the Gifford Fire, three other fires ultimately exceeding 100,000 acres emerged in northwest Colorado (Lee Fire), northern Nevada (Cottonwood Peak Fire), and central Wyoming (Red Canyon Fire) in August, but these all burned in relatively light fuels and did not require extended

commitments of national firefighting resources. As August was ending without any serious escalation in significant fire potential, the remaining Fuels and Fire Behavior Advisories for portions of Nevada and Southern California were allowed to expire.

In the eastern US, activity continued at normal levels in the Southern Area with periodic large fires in Texas. However, very dry conditions occurred during the month in much of the Eastern Area, focused from Missouri northeastward through the Ohio Valley and into the Northeast and Mid-Atlantic. Portions of Missouri, Illinois, Ohio, and northern New England received less than 25% of normal precipitation with rapid onset of drought, especially in New England. Few large fires occurred in these areas, but fire activity was well above normal, especially in northern New England. Maine recorded over 250 fires the month of August, which is more than double their previous record of just over 100 fires. Elsewhere, fire activity in Alaska dropped to the typical very low levels at the end of August.

September began very active in the Northwest as a significant dry lightning event hit Washington on the last day of August that continued into September 1. Numerous significant fires emerged, including the Lower Sugarloaf, Crown Creek, Katy Creek, Tacoma Creek, and Rattlesnake Fires. Moderate activity also continued in northern California and the Northern Rockies, with the national PL returning to four September 4. However, shortly after this lightning event, fire activity showed a seasonal downtrend in the West with the national PL falling to three September 12 and two September 23. The decrease in activity was most notable in California and Oregon as occasional wet thunderstorms developed and brought above normal rainfall along with elevated relative humidity. While above normal temperatures and drier than normal conditions continued in much of Washington into Montana in September, fire activity waned due to the lower sun angle and shorter days. Fires continued to burn but were much less active in the absence of wind. None of the large fires that emerged in September or later would exceed 50,000 acres despite early predictions for a longer and busier than normal peak fire season.

Farther east, conditions overall were dry for September from the southern Plains and Mississippi Valley to the East Coast. Only portions of the Tennessee and Ohio Valleys and Upper Peninsula of Michigan observed above normal rainfall for the month. Precipitation was more abundant on most of the northern and central Plains, with many areas receiving above normal precipitation for the month. Drought continued to intensify from Missouri into New England due to these dry conditions. Elevated initial attack, well above seasonal norms, continued for much of the month in these areas. Elevated initial attack and occasional large fires also persisted in Texas much of the month. Late in the month, the Northeast observed a decrease in the amount of initial attack as two storms brought widespread wetting rainfall to the region.

October – December

Significant fire activity continued to decrease through October with the national PL dropping to one October 10. Fire activity remained at low levels for the fourth quarter of the year, but periodic increases in activity occurred in the Southern Area, which is typical for the time of year. Overall, the fall period was very warm across the West into the Plains and Mississippi Valley, with temperatures averaging 5-10 degrees above normal for the three-month period across large portions of the Great Basin, Rockies, and High Plains. Temperatures from the Appalachians to the East Coast averaged near to below normal for the period.

The three-month period was wetter than normal across the West, especially in California where portions of Southern California received 200-400% of normal precipitation. Despite the wet period in the West, snowpack started the season below normal across most basins due to the very high snow levels. Several atmospheric rivers impacted the West Coast during the three-month period, including earlier than normal atmospheric rivers into California in October. Strong atmospheric rivers continued into California in November, which was the wettest month of the three in the southern portions of the state and resulted in areas of flooding. Most atmospheric rivers impacted the northern half of the West in December with well above normal precipitation, while the Greater Four Corners received much less precipitation, and portions of the Southwest were very dry. These atmospheric rivers brought very high snow levels averaging above 7,000 feet most of the month. The strongest of these atmospheric rivers in mid-December brought very high snow levels near or exceeding 10,000 feet and up to two feet of rain in the Washington Cascades. Historic flooding occurred in northwest Washington, with several rivers setting new records for crests and stream flows. Snow levels came down at the end of the month but remained above 5,000 feet in most locations. Aside from a few stations in the highest elevations in the northern Rockies and Sierra where the precipitation was mostly snow, snowpack was well below normal across much of the rest of the West. Snowpack was less than 50% of normal for most locations in the southern Rockies into the southern and western Great Basin, Oregon, and northern California. A few basins in the Southwest had little to no snowpack and were less than 5% of normal at the end of the year.

In contrast, precipitation across much of the eastern U.S. was below normal, with much of the central and southern Plains well below normal as less than 25% of normal precipitation occurred in portions of Nebraska, Oklahoma, and Texas. Precipitation was also well below normal in the Southeast to the Mid-Atlantic where 30-70% of normal precipitation occurred. Despite the drier than normal conditions, significant fire activity was relegated to short periods and not unusual for the time of year. While the dry conditions promoted receptive fuels and initial attack was elevated across the central Plains, Front Range, and most of the Southern Area, the lack of strong wind events helped to keep significant activity very low. However, there were two very strong downslope wind events on the Front Range in mid-December with peak wind gusts near 100 mph with relative humidity below 20%. However, mitigation efforts including public safety power shutoffs resulted in limited activity on the Front Range and only one significant fire arose on the plains of far eastern Colorado.